





MAKING WAVES (clockwise from left) Artworks from *Andha Ras*, *Trespassers*, and *metromorphosis*

ART

THE BOMBAY **SPIRIT**

The Mumbai Urban Art Festival dives into the coastal city's relationship with the sea

On a recent Sunday, Mumbaikars descended upon Sassoon Dock, one of the city's oldest and a busy fishing harbour. This was, however, not to buy fresh catch of the day but to capture artworks adorning the walls of the commercial buildings in the area. Part of the three-month-long Mumbai Urban Art Festival, which runs till March and is presented by Asian Paints and the St+art India Foundation, the murals (which will be permanent) featuring marine life and lifesize portraits of Koli fisherwomen are just some of the pieces of fine art in the area. Given the location, water is a key component of many artworks. It is most evident in the exhibit 'Intuitions' (running till Feb. 22), where various artists focus on our evolving relationship with the sea. Two videos reflect it the best. In Meera Devidayal's *Water Has Memory* (2018), reflections of the Arabian Sea on the windows of the buildings around Nariman Point become a canvas to capture people in spaces, the changing form of the sea and its varied effects. In Sohrab Hura's engaging *The Coast* (2020), the camera records the joy, the panic, the melancholia, the surprise—in slow motion—that the sea evokes among devotees during a religious festivity celebrating Kali.

Other notable works include Sameer Kulavoor and Sandeep Meher's mixed media installation 'metromorphosis' which presents a sprawling, intricately detailed version of Mumbai with its obsession for grills, skyscrapers, flyovers and tin-roofed settlements. The miniature-sized drab grey models perched on bright crates highlight the stuffiness and class disparity in the 'Maximum City'. A crowd favourite, going by the photo frenzy, are the brightly coloured murals of dockyard life—a sleeping dog, an egret flying by—created by Kerala-based art collective Trespassers. There's art everywhere, even in the men's urinal, where the photo exhibit by Naman Saraiya and Nikita Rana is aptly titled "this is a photo dump", and on the rooftop, where an empty water tank holds the early morning sounds from the bustling Sassoon Dock as you hear actual ones from the harbour nearby.

> St+art aims to create **more public art every two years** so as to put Mumbai on the global map of leading urban art

In the recently-opened 'Illusions' (also running till Feb 22), light-based works get prominence on the lower level. The MUAF will expand to Mahim East and Bandra later on. The former, which is already known for its murals, will get three more, while the latter will have two temporary installations and a permanent artwork over the Carter Road skatepark. St+art aims to create more public art every two years so as to "put Mumbai on the global map of leading urban art" and "to embed it in everyday life". With its balance of alluring, crowd-pleasing works and ones that compel viewers to sit down and reflect, MUAF makes for a wholesome outing. ■

Suhani Singh

PAINTING THE TOWN

Kicking off the culture season in the nation's cultural capital was the 12th edition of the Mumbai Gallery Weekend. The four-day event may have ended on January 15, but many of the shows that marked it continue

At Chemould Prescott Rd. *Until Feb. 17*

Atul Dodiya's *Dr. Banerjee in Dr. Kulkarni's Nursing Home and Other Paintings 2020-2022* is a dazzling series inspired by cinema and transforming flickering frames into an homage with resonances of lobby cards and affectionate reference to the history of art, both pop and popular.





Chemould Prescott Rd. *Until Feb. 25*

Rithika Pandey's *Birth of Forgiveness* is plainly an act of reconciliation with pain and loss, her images combining visions of nature, fecundity and wounds with a vocabulary of folk art and mythology suffused with bahrupiyas and strange fruit.

Chatterjee & Lal, Mumbai *Until Feb. 25*

Nityan Unnikrishnan's *Every Day is an Admission of Guilt* presents more of his acerbic and arrestingly detailed paintings. The continuing evolution of his palette and imagery is a delight, and his phantasmagoric return to ceramics a bonus.

